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Nail, spike

1.12.2 Nail, spike

References:

Hebrew מַסְמֵר (masmer) 1CH 22:3, 2CH 3:9, ISA 41:7, JER 10:4

Hebrew מַשְׁמֵרָה (masmerah) ECC 12:11

Greek ἦλος (hēlos) JHN 20:25, JHN 20:25

Description:

Spike in an anklebone (Gary Todd, Israel Museum, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons)The nail was a thin piece of metal (usually iron) sharpened on one end. It served much the same purpose as a modern nail, attaching pieces of wood to each other or to the floor.

The spike for crucifixion was a fairly thick, pointed piece of iron. It was roughly 20 centimeters (8 inches) long and about the thickness of a man's finger. Archaeological excavations in 1968 uncovered the remains of a crucified man. A metal spike was still lodged in an anklebone, passing through it from the side.

Translation:

In a number of languages a distinction is made between relatively small nails and larger spikes. The latter would be appropriate when speaking of crucifixion and probably for the spikes used in gate construction in 1CH 22:3. The word chosen should indicate a spike strong enough that two or three of them would have held the weight of a man.

Roman-era rought iron nails (© Takkk, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The nails mentioned in 2CH 3:9 were made of gold and varied widely in size.